

Trade and culture

During the 17th, 18th, and 19th centuries trade thrived, though some Asian countries were closed to outsiders. Russia and European countries bought silk, tea, and porcelain from China. India traded with the world, and was famous for its handmade textiles, such as "paisley", which was a traditional Indian pattern. During this period, Western powers became increasingly interested in annexing Asian territories for trade purposes.



Mountains of Lake Baikal, Russia

Great Game

During the 1800s, Russia expanded into Central Asia. The British feared the Russians were aiming to take over India, and both sides began to spy on each other. The British called this the Great Game; to the Russians it was known as the Tournament of Shadows.

Manchu Dynasty

China's Manchu Dynasty (1644–1911) was expansionist, and spread its culture by acquiring other territories, such as Mongolia (1697), Tibet (1751), and eastern Turkestan (1760). At home, however, economic conditions worsened.



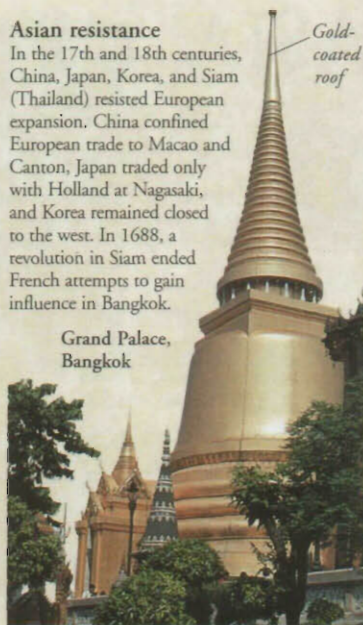
Yellow lotus is a sacred flower.

A rich woman's silk robe, 19th century

Asian resistance

In the 17th and 18th centuries, China, Japan, Korea, and Siam (Thailand) resisted European expansion. China confined European trade to Macao and Canton, Japan traded only with Holland at Nagasaki, and Korea remained closed to the west. In 1688, a revolution in Siam ended French attempts to gain influence in Bangkok.

Grand Palace, Bangkok



Nineteenth-century colonization

In the 19th century, European powers colonized much of Asia. The British took over Burma, Malaya, North Borneo, and Hong Kong; France dominated Indochina; the Dutch controlled Indonesia; and Russia annexed Central Asian provinces.

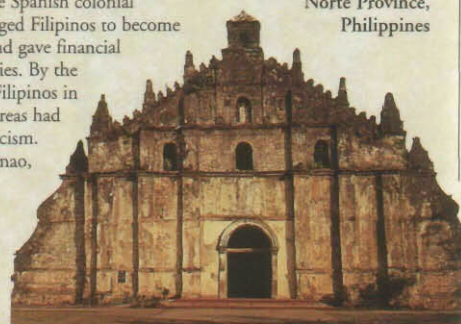
Britain
Russia
France
Netherlands
Japan



Conversion of the Philippines

In the late 1500s, the Spanish colonial government encouraged Filipinos to become Roman Catholics, and gave financial support to missionaries. By the 18th century, most Filipinos in towns and lowland areas had converted to Catholicism. The island of Mindanao, however, embraced Islam, which was brought to them by Muslim traders.

Paoay church, Ilocos Norte Province, Philippines



Engraving of Anglo-Burmese wars, 1824

Anglo-Burmese wars

In 1886, Burma lost its independence to Britain after a series of wars. This takeover was strategic rather than trade-based: the British wanted to prevent the French from gaining too much influence in Asia.

Golden East

As Europe gained in military and industrial strength in the 19th century, it expanded, and Asia became a rich source of food and raw materials. European planters developed tea, coffee, and rubber plantations, founded tin mines, exploited Asian timber, and prospected for gold, silver, and precious stones.



Indian tea



Vietnamese mahogany

Rama V

Chulalongkorn (1853–1910) became Rama V, King of Siam, in 1868. He travelled widely throughout Asia, and was determined to strengthen his country by a process of modernization. In the 1880s, he created a modern army, civil service, and education system. Although Thailand lost some provinces to Britain and France, it managed to preserve its prestige and independence.



The king and queen of Siam

Rebellion

From the 1850s, there were rebellions against European interference in Asian affairs. In 1857, the Sepoy Rebellion took place in India, and, in 1900, there was the Boxer Rebellion in China. Both revolts were protests against western strength and culture. They were crushed by western or colonial government forces.



Cover of *Le Petit Parisien*, 1900, "Death to Foreigners"

Timeline

4000–c.2500 BC The world's earliest civilization flourishes in Sumer, western Asia.

c.2500 BC Indus Valley period, India's earliest civilization.

1800 BC Shang period: China's earliest civilization starts to build its first cities.

c.330 BC Alexander the Great destroys the Persian Empire.

138 BC First recorded journey on the Silk Road.

c.50 Buddhism reaches China from India.

206 BC–AD 220 Height of the Chinese Han Empire.

FIND OUT MORE

ARCHITECTURE CHINA, HISTORY OF CONFUCIUS